

Lesson 01: Exercise in Game Narrative

The Story of Space Invaders

Description

Space Invaders is a 1978 video game and is commonly considered to be one of the most influential video games of all time, Space Invaders was the first fixed shooter and set the template for the genre. The goal is to defeat wave after wave of descending aliens with a horizontally moving laser cannon to earn as many points as possible.

The player moves a laser cannon horizontally across the bottom of the screen and fires at aliens overhead. The aliens begin as five rows of eleven that move left and right as a group, shifting downward (advancing on the shooter) each time they reach a screen edge. The goal is to eliminate all of the aliens by shooting them. While the player has three lives, the game ends immediately if the invaders reach the bottom of the screen.

https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Space_Invaders



Activity 1: Students play the game using the following online emulators:

1. <https://arcadespot.com/game/space-invaders/>
2. <https://freeinvaders.org/>
3. <https://www.crazygames.com/game/space-invaders>

Activity 2: Discussion - Narrative in students' favorite games

1. Ask students to name their favorite video game and think/discuss the following:
 - a. What is the game's setting? Where does the game take place?
 - b. Why did the designers choose that particular setting/place?
 - c. Who is the main character?
 - d. What is the main character's motivation for action? In other words, why does the main character behave the way they do?
 - e. Would the game change if the main character were different?
 - f. What story does the game try to tell us?

Activity 3: Discussion - Narrative in Space Invaders.

When Space Invaders was designed, it was created as a very simple game that could be played over a very short period of time in an arcade. The designers of the game did not really think about the narrative, setting, background story, or the player's motivations. Or did they?

Imagine that you are hired to redesign Space Invaders. In order to redesign the game, you really need to understand what is going on in the current version. Think about Space Invaders and work with a partner or in a small group to answer the following questions:

1. Who are the aliens?
2. What is the name of their alien race?
3. What is the name of their planet?
4. What language do they speak?
5. What does their planet look like?
6. Why did they come to earth?
7. Are they actually attacking our planet, or maybe they came on a peaceful research mission?
8. Who is the player?
9. Why is the player alone?
10. Why is the player fighting the aliens?
11. Are there other people left on earth?
12. Did the player try to communicate with the aliens, or did they just start shooting?
13. What technology does the player's spaceship use?

Think about these questions and write a story from the perspective of the aliens or from the perspective of the player.